

Economics in the News

Essay Writing Guideline

This covers the three “Economics in the News” essays. It explains what they require and how to write one well.

Most of what follows is general college-writing advice, not just rules specific to this assignment.



What Your Essay Must Do

Find a recent news article and analyze it using economic concepts from class. Your essay must:

1. Summarize the article and cite its source.
2. Identify the economic concept(s) that apply.
3. Analyze the situation using those concepts, with a diagram where appropriate.
4. If the article raises a policy question, distinguish positive analysis (what would happen) from normative judgment (what should be done).

Length: 500–700 words, roughly two pages, double-spaced, 12pt font. This word count is for your text; diagrams are not included (see the Diagrams slide).

Example Articles

These are real, recent articles. They are not required reading, just examples of the kind of piece that works.

- **“TSMC to raise prices by up to 10% in 2026, citing US tariffs as a factor.”** TechSpot, Sept. 2, 2025.

Angle: tariffs as a tax, cost-push pricing, market power.

<https://www.techspot.com/news/109296-tsmc-raise-chip-prices-up-10-2026-citing.html>

- **“Minimum wage to be raised again this year, Lai says.”** Taipei Times, Jan. 6, 2026.

Angle: price floors, positive versus normative debate.

<https://www.taipeitimes.com/News/front/archives/2026/01/06/2003850113>

- **“Taiwan’s house prices continue to slide.”** Taiwan News, Feb. 20, 2026.

Angle: supply and demand, credit policy.

<https://www.taiwannews.com.tw/news/6305945>

Example Topics and Questions

- Why are Taipei housing prices falling even as foreign buyer demand rises?
- Should Taiwan keep raising its minimum wage, given the cost to small businesses?
- How do US tariffs on Taiwanese chips affect TSMC's pricing and Apple's costs?
- Why do vegetable or egg prices spike after a typhoon, and how long does it last?

Pick an article first, then ask which question it lets you answer.



No Section Headings

Use a title specific to your topic, not “Essay 1,” at the top, followed directly by your text.

Do not use section headings such as “Summary” or “Analysis.”

Professional economic writing, such as opinion columns, policy briefs, or the article you are analyzing, does not use headings either. It relies on topic sentences and transitions to carry the structure.

The first sentence of each paragraph should state that paragraph’s job, so a reader skimming only the first sentences could still follow the argument.

One Way to Structure Six Paragraphs

1. Introduce the article and cite the source. This is your summary.
2. Name the economic concept(s) that apply, and say why.
- 3–4. Analyze the situation using those concepts, with a diagram if you have one.
5. If relevant, distinguish positive from normative claims.
6. A short closing that returns to why the story matters.

This is one reasonable structure, not a required template. An essay without a clear policy angle may need only four or five paragraphs.

Sample Topic Sentences

Example. Beneath the headline numbers, this price increase is a textbook illustration of a supply shock.

Example. To see why the shortage emerged, consider the market for rice using a standard supply-and-demand diagram.

Example. It is worth separating what this policy will do from what it should do.



Transitions Carry the Structure

- **To add a point:** moreover, in addition, similarly.
- **To contrast:** however, by contrast, even so.
- **To show cause and effect:** as a result, because, this in turn.
- **To illustrate:** for example, consider, to see why.
- **To concede before pivoting:** granted, while it is true that
- **To shift positive to normative:** setting aside whether this is desirable

A paragraph that opens with a genuine transition, rather than a new topic dropped in cold, reads as one continuous argument.

Sentence-Level Style

Much of this follows Strunk and White's *The Elements of Style*.

- Prefer the active voice: “The central bank raised interest rates,” not “Interest rates were raised.”
- Omit needless words. Cut throat-clearing openers like “In today’s society.” Start with the point.
- Use concrete language: the actual number from your article, not a vague generality.
- Prefer strong verbs to nominalizations: “the government decided,” not “made a decision.”

Making the Economic Argument

Graff and Birkenstein's *They Say / I Say* frames academic writing as a move between what “they say” and what “I say.”

The article is “they say,” what the reporter or source claims or observes. Your analysis is “I say,” what economic theory adds once you look past the headline.

Example. The article reports that Economically, this reflects ..., because



Positive versus Normative Language

When the article raises a policy question, watch your verbs.

Positive claims describe what is or will happen: “will,” “is likely to,” “causes,” “predicts.”

Normative claims say what should happen: “should,” “ought to,” “it would be fair to.”

Keep these separate, and signal the shift explicitly. For example, “Setting aside what should be done, standard theory predicts that the price ceiling will create a shortage.”



Diagrams

If you include a diagram, number it (“Figure 1”), give it a short caption, and refer to it explicitly in your text.

Place it near the paragraph that discusses it.

It does not need to be beautifully drawn. A clear hand-drawn diagram, photographed or scanned, is perfectly fine, but every curve, axis, and shift it shows must be labeled and must match what your text says.

Remark. The 500–700 word, two-page length requirement covers your written text only. A diagram, and its caption, do not count against it, so a large or hand-drawn diagram can reasonably push a submission to three pages.

Citing Your Source and Avoiding Plagiarism

In your opening paragraph, give enough information for a reader to find your article. Include the publication, title, author if listed, and date.

Quote sparingly and only when the original wording matters; otherwise, paraphrase in your own words, and attribute the idea to the article even when you are not quoting it directly.

As the syllabus states, plagiarism includes unacknowledged word-for-word use or paraphrasing of another person's work. Using generative AI critically is allowed, but review everything it drafts. Unexamined AI text risks quietly reproducing someone else's wording without credit.

Remark. Concepts and terms learned in class, opportunity cost, comparative advantage, a price ceiling, need no citation. They are the course's shared vocabulary, not someone else's original words or ideas.

Grading Rubric

Category	Points	What Earns Full Credit
Summary & citation	10	Clear summary; source is easy to find
Economic concept	20	Correct, specific concept(s) named
Analysis	35	Concept applied correctly, with real depth
Positive/normative	15	Explicitly distinguished, when relevant
Writing craft	15	Topic sentences, transitions, concise style
Mechanics	5	Length, proper attribution

100 points total, worth 5% of the course grade. If an article has no clear policy angle, the 15 positive/normative points shift to Analysis instead.

Rubric Performance Tiers

Within each category above, points are awarded by how well that category is done, using the same numeric grading scale as the syllabus.

Tier(s)	% of that category's points	Description
A+	90–100%	Excellent: exceeds the expectation
A, A-	80–89%	Strong: meets the expectation well
B+, B, B-	70–79%	Satisfactory: meets the basic expectation
C+, C, C-	60–69%	Weak: falls short in significant ways
D or below	below 60%	Poor: largely fails to meet the expectation

For example, on Analysis (35 points), 32 or above is excellent, 28–31 is strong, 25–27 is satisfactory, 21–24 is weak, and below 21 is poor.

Before You Submit

- Does the first sentence of every paragraph state that paragraph's job?
- Does each paragraph connect to the one before it with a transition?
- Have you cut throat-clearing openings and sentences that do not add information?
- Is every claim about what *will* happen kept separate from what *should* happen?
- If you used a diagram, is it numbered, captioned, labeled, and referred to by name?
- Could a reader find your source article from your first paragraph?



Further Reading

- William Strunk Jr. and E.B. White, *The Elements of Style*: sentence-level clarity and concision.
- Gerald Graff and Cathy Birkenstein, *They Say / I Say*: framing analysis as a response to someone else's claim.
- Gordon Harvey, *Elements of the Academic Essay* (Harvard College Writing Program): whole-essay structure.

